the famous 438 game is a prime example of that attitude (more about that later).

Ja, Fletchie is always telling me to ‘play it as you see it’. He never tells me to play myself in. Not ever. Graham Ford, who took over as Proteas coach from Bob Woolmer, wasn’t too bad either, allowing me the freedom to go out and express myself. But the coaches who came after him – Ray Jennings, Eric Simons, Mickey Arthur and now Corrie van Zyl – were all pretty conservative in their approach.

I don’t know how many times I’ve been told that the first hour of a Test match always belongs to the bowler. Well, someone clearly forgot to tell Michael Slater. Or Sanath Jayasuriya. If the first ball asks to be hit over cover, they happily oblige.

Yes, the downside to being an attacking batsman – especially when you’re opening and facing the new ball – is that you do often go out to rash shots. It’s not as if I don’t know this. Trust me.

There have been plenty of times I have been out on shots I know I should never have attempted, even as an attacking player. I wish I knew why I played those shots. I have never been able to figure that out about my game. It’s just such an instinctive thing. I mean, I wouldn’t purposefully want to play a bad shot. Fletchie always said I just play it like I see it … and unfortunately I haven’t seen the ball so well at times. It’s frustrating when you’re back in the dressing room and you’re watching a TV replay of your dismissal. But I’ve always taken solace in the fact that I got out trying to play a shot. In this case, obviously a kak shot.

But it’s particularly hard for me to watch a replay of my dismissal when I know I’ve gone out playing tentatively. It pisses me off so much, I can’t even watch it. If I’ve been defending against a good ball and I’ve nicked it or been bowled, then fair enough – all credit to the bowler. But I hate losing my wicket because I’ve been asked to play conservatively and, as a consequence, have tightened up.

The 2005/06 series against Australia in Australia was a prime example of how it messes up my game when I play too tentatively. We played three Tests against the Aussies in December and January, and then hosted them in South Africa during March/April. As you no doubt recall, we were humbled, losing the series 0-2 in Oz and then 0-3 in South Africa.

There’s no doubt in my mind that I was way too hesitant, against Brett Lee in particular. I was too focused on trying to play myself in and to figure